

Fundworthy ●

# Finding funding worth your time

A short guide to setting this up and using it each week —  
written for the person who will actually use it, not for a  
developer.

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Prepared for **Mauri Hamilton, COO** — RISE San Diego

Built at the AI Trailblazers Social Impact Hack-AI-thon, San Diego • August 2026

RISE San Diego owns this work.

# What this does, in three sentences

Each week it visits the websites of funders that give money to San Diego nonprofits and reads their grant pages. It throws out anything too small, anything closing too soon, and anything RISE cannot apply for — before spending a cent. What survives appears on one page, best first, with a one-line reason and a link to the funder's own page.

## What it deliberately does *not* do

It does not try to find *more* grants. Finding them was never the hard part — the problem is that most of what turns up is too small to justify a ten-hour application. So it is built to return **few** results. Six good ones is a good week. If it returns three, that is not a malfunction.

It never writes an application, never emails anyone on RISE's behalf, and **never states a dollar amount or a deadline it did not read on the funder's own page**. When it cannot find one, it says “not stated” instead of guessing.

**The one rule behind everything.** Funders read what you send them. A made-up deadline that costs you a submission is far worse than a blank you can fill in with one click on the link. Every number in this tool either came off the funder's page, or is marked as the assistant's own judgement.

## Two kinds of number, and telling them apart

|                         |                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Plain text              | Read directly off the funder's page. If we could not confirm it there, it is left blank rather than filled in.                                                                                                   |
| <div>something AI</div> | The assistant's judgement — how well it fits, how many hours it might take, how long until money arrives. Useful, but it is an opinion, and it is drawn differently so you always know which you are looking at. |

# Setting it up

About five minutes, and you should not need to come back to it.

## 1 Open the app

Double-click `start.sh` in the project folder. A window appears with some text in it — leave that window open, it is the app running. It prints a web address: `http://localhost:8000`. Open that in your browser.

The first time takes about a minute while it installs itself. After that it is instant. Everything lives on this computer — there is no password because there is nothing to log in to.

## 2 Add the AI key

Go to

### Settings

. The key is what pays for the reading and scoring — think of it as the researcher's bus fare. At this volume it costs a couple of dollars a month, and every search stops itself at the limit you set.

Fundworthy •
  
  
This week
  
  
Past findings
  
  
Settings

## Settings

Set up once. You shouldn't need to come back here often.

### Your AI key

The key is what pays for the reading and scoring — think of it as the researcher's bus fare. At this volume it costs a couple of dollars a month, and every search stops itself at the limit you set.

- Go to [console.anthropic.com](https://console.anthropic.com) and sign up — like creating any online account.
- Open **API keys**, press **Create key**, and copy the text that starts with `sk-ant-`.
- Paste it below and press Save. Whoever's account it is pays the bill.

**No key is saved here** — but the researcher is using one (`sk-ant-...VAAA`) from a `.env` file on this computer, so searches will still be scored. That file is for developers. Saving a key here takes priority over it, and is the one to rely on.

Paste your key

sk-ant-...

Save key

### Organization

Used wherever this app names you. Leave it blank and it says "your organization" rather than guessing.

Organization name

Your organization

Where you work

San Diego County, California

Save

Inviting teammates and switching between organizations needs accounts, which this version does not have — see HANDOFF.md.

### Turning it off

The switch lives on **This week**, under "Adjust search settings". Turn it off and nothing runs and nothing is spent until you turn it back on. You don't need to ask anyone.

### Where your data lives

Runs on this computer.  
Nothing is public.

Settings → **Your AI key**. Three steps, then paste and press Save. Once saved, this page can only ever show you the last four characters — that is deliberate.

**Whoever's account that key belongs to pays the bill.** It is a couple of dollars a month, but it should be a decision someone made rather than one that happened. Write the name down before you go further.

# Telling it what you are looking for

1 Tick the programs you want searched

Each RISE program is a card under

Your programs

. Ticking one is the whole activation. Three are ticked to begin with: Arts, Resilience & Renewal, and Urban Leadership Fellows.

2 Fill in the empty cards — or leave them

Four cards (ILIA, RISE Now, On the RISE, Nonprofit Partnerships Training) have a name and nothing else, on purpose: we only put in what you told us, and we were not going to invent a description of your own programme. To fill one in, press

Edit

, paste that programme's page from your website, and press

“Read this page for me.”

The assistant reads the page and fills the card in. Read it over and fix anything wrong — it will tell you what it could not find. Nothing is saved until you press Save.

3 Check the funder list

52 funders are searched each week, and every one had its grants page opened and read before it went on the list. The important control is the tick box on the left.

## The remove list

You told us you do not want opportunities from funders you already receive money from — you get those cheques without reapplying. So **nine things start on the remove list**, and an unticked funder is never visited, never read, and never scored. It costs nothing every week, rather than a little every week.

|                        |                                                                                                                                                                        |
|------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Already funding you    | San Diego Foundation · Alliance Healthcare · Prebys · City Economic Development · City Arts & Culture · California Arts Council · the Morales Fund · the Villegas Fund |
| Done — no more funding | County Equity Impact Grant. Note this removes that <i>one programme</i> , not the whole County: other County grants are still searched.                                |

If any of those is wrong — if one is a funder you *would* reapply to — tick it back on and it returns to the search immediately. Nothing was deleted.

# Using it

Press **Search again now**. It takes about eight minutes and shows you what it is doing as it goes. Then read the list.

Fundworthy •

This week

Past findings

Settings

### This week

8 opportunities found · every one cleared your \$10,000 floor

[Download spreadsheet](#)[Search again now](#)

✳ New here? The list below is what the researcher found this week. Open one to see why it scored the way it did — anything marked **AI** is the researcher's judgement, everything else is quoted from the funder's page.

Dismiss

Scoring is running on a key from a `.env` file on this computer, not one saved in **Settings**. Fine for development — but save a key on the Settings page so it does not depend on that file.

● Researcher is on | Last search: **2026-08-02 15:30 PDT** | Spent **\$0.4735** of \$1.00 [Adjust search settings](#)

Checked every funder on your list.

Some funders could not be checked this time, so this list may be short for that reason rather than because there was nothing to find:  
California Board of State and Community Corrections (BSCC) — California Violence Intervention and Prevention (CalVIP), County of San Diego, County of San Diego — Community Enhancement Program, Hearst Foundations, The NAMM Foundation — Music Program Grants.

### Worth a look — 3

Ranked best first. "Not stated" means the funder's page didn't say — the researcher never guesses.

12%

FIT · AI

**Doris Duke Foundation — Performing Arts** [More details](#)

Letter of Inquiry | Doris Duke Foundation

Amount not stated

Deadline not stated

~5h to apply **AI**

18%

FIT · AI

**National Endowment for the Arts — Grants for Arts Projects** [More details](#)

Priorities | National Endowment for the Arts

Amount not stated

Deadline not stated

~20h to apply — over the 10-hour cap **AI**

3%

FIT · AI

**State of California** [Public database](#) [More details](#)

Extreme Heat and Community Resilience Program Round 2

\$750,000–\$4,500,000

Due 2026-10-13 · 72d left

~40h to apply — over the 10-hour cap **AI**

### Needs your eyes — 5

The researcher reported something it could **not** confirm on the funder's page, so the value was removed rather than shown. Worth opening the link yourself. It should be rare; if it is not, tell us, because it means the reading step is drifting.

28%

FIT · AI

**The Andy Warhol Foundation for the Visual Arts** [Unverified claim](#) [More details](#)

Application Guidelines — The Andy Warhol Foundation for the Visual Arts

Amount not stated

Rolling deadline

~10h to apply **AI**

[Check the listing yourself ↗](#) Found 2026-08-02

Runs on this computer.  
Nothing is public.

This week — the search controls and status at the top, your programmes and funders below, and the findings underneath.

## Reading a result

|                |                                                                                                                                                                 |
|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The big number | How well the assistant thinks this funder fits a RISE programme. Its judgement, not a fact from the page.                                                       |
| Score          | Out of 100, and what the list is sorted by. Programme fit 40, award size 35, whether the application can realistically be finished in time 25 — your weighting. |

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|                            |                                                                                                                                            |
|----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>“Amount not stated”</b> | Normal. Most funders do not publish one — we checked across 155 pages. The score already accounts for it.                                  |
| <b>“Needs your eyes”</b>   | Rare, and worth opening. It means the assistant reported something it could <b>not</b> confirm against the page, so the value was removed. |
| <b>Their 990</b>           | Links to the funder's actual IRS filing, where we could identify them — so a funder that reads big on its own website can be checked.      |

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# The controls that matter

## Turning it off

On **This week**, press **Adjust search settings** and untick “**The researcher is on.**” Nothing runs — no searching, no spending — until you turn it back on. Nothing is deleted; your existing results stay. You do not need to ask anyone. If a search is running right now, **Stop** ends it immediately.

## What you can change

|                                   |                                                                                |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Smallest award worth applying for | \$10,000. The most important setting — anything smaller is never shown to you. |
| Ignore anything due sooner than   | 14 days. Less runway than that and a good application is not possible.         |
| Most results to bring back        | 12. Sized for a one-hour review.                                               |
| Most to spend on one search       | \$1.00. It stops rather than going over.                                       |
| Where to look                     | Which kinds of funder: partners, foundations, government RFPs, arts agencies.  |

## Keeping a copy

**Download as a spreadsheet** in the page header gives you the week as a file you can open in Excel or Google Sheets, or forward to Veronica.

## Past findings

Everything found this month, including what you have already reviewed. The archive keeps the current month — when a search runs in a new month, the previous month's rows are cleared. That is what stops you being shown the same grant every week, and it means anything still open gets a fresh look next month rather than being hidden forever.



# When something looks wrong

| WHAT YOU SEE                                 | WHAT TO DO                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| “Could not reach the app”                    | The app is not running. Double-click <code>start.sh</code> again.                                                        |
| Results appear but nothing is scored         | No AI key saved, or it expired. Settings → paste a key → <b>Check it works</b> .                                         |
| Nothing new found                            | Normal. Everything it found, you have already seen this month. Check <b>Past findings</b> .                              |
| “Hit the spending limit”                     | Normal. It protected the budget. Results are valid, just fewer.                                                          |
| A funder keeps saying “could not be reached” | They changed their website. Edit that funder and fix the address.                                                        |
| Most results say “Needs your eyes”           | That should be rare. If most of a week lands there, tell whoever maintains this — it means the reading step is drifting. |

Nothing here is urgent. A missed week costs one week of results. Do not let anyone tell you this needs an emergency fix.

## Honest limitations

Read these before trusting a result.

1. **The scores have never been checked against your judgement.** We have a test for exactly that, built from five grants you would say yes to and five you would say no to — but you have not given us those ten yet, so it runs on examples we wrote. Treat every score as a starting point for your judgement, not a substitute.
2. **Almost no funder publishes a deadline we can read.** Across 155 pages we extracted almost none. Always confirm the deadline on the funder's page before committing to an application.
3. **“Who this funder has given to before” is not in here.** It is not available from any free source — the only route is a paid service like Candid. The 990 link is the closest we can get; the grantee list is a scroll away on that page.
4. **It only knows about the funders on its list.** 52 of them, researched for San Diego and California nonprofits. Adding more is data entry, not programming.

# What it costs, and who owns it

|                |                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| The AI         | Under \$1 a month at this volume. A measured full search costs about 50 cents, with a hard \$1.00 ceiling per search enforced in the code — it stops and says why rather than overspending. |
| The app itself | Free. It runs on your computer.                                                                                                                                                             |
| Total          | Under \$1 a month, against a \$20 ceiling.                                                                                                                                                  |

**Nobody owns the API key yet.** This is the thing most likely to quietly kill the project. Whoever's key is pasted into Settings is paying, so that needs a name.

Owner: ..... · Payment method: .....

## Where your data lives

One file: `data/rise.db` , in the project folder. It holds your settings, your programmes, your funder list, this month's findings, and the encrypted key. **Back it up by copying that file.** Do not email it or put it in a shared folder — the key is inside it.

## The thirty-day question

An unmaintained tool is a liability, not an asset. Funders redesign their websites; when one does, this will say “could not be reached” into an empty room. It needs an owner — someone who opens it once a month and notices — rather than a maintainer.

AI Trailblazers runs a paid apprenticeship that places people with nonprofits for exactly this. That is the realistic answer, and it is worth raising directly rather than hoping the team absorbs it.

## The first four things to do

1. Open it on your own computer and run one search.
2. Put a name against the API key.
3. Give us five grants you would say yes to, and five you would say no to.
4. Tell us which of the eight removed funders is wrong, if any.